



SOCIOLOGY – AN INTRODUCTION

INTRODUCTION

Sociology is a branch of the social sciences that uses systematic methods of empirical investigation and critical analysis to develop and refine a body of knowledge about human social structure and activity, sometimes with the goal of applying such knowledge to the pursuit of social welfare. Its subject matter ranges from the micro level of face-to-face interaction to the macro level of societies at large.



Sociology is a broad discipline in terms of both methodology and subject matter. Its traditional focuses have included social relations, social stratification, social interaction, culture and deviance, and its approaches have included both qualitative and quantitative research techniques. As much of what humans do fits under the category of social structure or social activity, sociology has gradually expanded its focus to such far-flung subjects as the study of economic activity, health disparities, and even the role of social activity in the creation of scientific knowledge. The range of social scientific methods has also been broadly expanded. The "cultural turn" of the 1970s and 1980s brought more humanistic interpretive approaches to the study of culture in sociology. Conversely, the same decades saw the rise of new mathematically rigorous approaches, such as social network analysis. Hence, sociology encompasses all social aspects of human's life.

Meaning:

The word Sociology is a combination of two words given below.

Sociology = Socious + Logus

Derived from = Latin + Greek

Meaning = People + to study or understand

Hence, scientific study of people is called sociology.

Definitions

Sociology has been defined in a number of ways by a number of people.

- "The science of society" (**Ward and Graham Sumner**).
- "The science of social phenomena" (**F.H. Giddings**).
- "The science of institutions" (**Durkheim**).
- "The science of social organization and social change" (**Kovalevsky**).
- "The science of studying human relationship" (**Simmel**).
- "The study of social action" (**Weber**).
- "The science of collective behavior" (**Park**).

Some of the contemporaries' define sociology in this way:

- **Ken Browne:** *sociology is the systematic (or planned and organized) study of human groups and social life in modern societies.*
- **William E. Cole:** *"sociology is the study of social systems."*
- **Ian Robertson:** *"sociology is the scientific study of human society and social behavior."*
- **John J. Maccionis:** *"sociology is the systematic study of human society."*
- **Kalhoun, Light and Keller:** *"sociology is the study of human society, including both social action and social organization."*

Having a review of all the above definitions, it is concluded that sociology is the

scientific study of social relations. Ultimately it is the study of human society. To be more operational, sociology is "the scientific study of structure and function of human groups" (Parsons). From all these definitions, we conclude that sociology is the systematic study of human behaviour.

Origin and Development of Sociology

Sociology of today is the product of man's old experiences and observations. Sociology—the science of society, was originated as a special discipline, in 1836 by August Comte, a French, with the name of 'Social Physics'. Though it is a new discipline, its foundation was laid by Allama Ibn-e-Khaldun (1332–1406 A.D.), a Muslim historian of Tunis. He named this new science "Ilmul-Imran" — study of people and said that no historian could write the history of a nation until he studied Ilmul-Imran—the social life of that population. Ibn-e-Khaldun's famous work on sociological contributions is his "Muqadamah".

The old Muslim thinkers were Al-Raazi, Al-Kundi, Al-Farabi (870–950 A.D), Ibn-e-Sina (980–1067 A.D), Al-Mawardi (974–1058 A.D), Imam Ghazali (1058–1111 A.D), Shah Wali Ullah Dehlvi (1702–1763 A.D) and others. The European old social thinkers were Aristotle (384–322 B.C.) the Socrates, the Plato (427–347 B.C.), Machiavelli, Thomas Hobbes, Kant and others. Some of the notable thinkers of modern times are Spencer, Pareto, Durkheim, Parsons, Weber, Inkles, Park, Burgess, Timasheff, Mead, Simmel, Maciver, Page, Ogburn, Nimkoff and Martindale. The efforts of these thinkers have developed sociology as a new science.

EARLY SOCIOLOGISTS

Given the social conditions that provoked their inquiry, the early sociologists focused their attention on the forces that hold society together and on the forces that fragment it.

Auguste Comte

The title "founder of sociology" usually goes to the French philosopher Auguste Comte (1798-1857). Comte was a somewhat eccentric person (he claimed to practice "mental hygiene," meaning that he refused to read anyone else's books), but was one of the most original thinkers of his time. It was he, who coined the term "sociology" and who argued, in 1838, that the methods of science should be applied to the study of society. Comte established two specific problems for sociological

investigation, "social statics" and "social dynamics." Social statics refers to the problem of order and stability—how and why do societies hold together and endure? Social dynamics refers to the problem of social change—what makes societies change and what shapes the nature and direction of the changes? Comte was so confident that the scientific method would unlock the secrets of society that he came to regard sociologists as a "priesthood of humanity," experts who would not only explain social events but would also guide society in the direction of greater progress. Although later sociologists have generally had more modest ambitions, they have continued to wrestle with the problems of social order and social change.

Herbert Spencer

Another important nineteenth-century figure was Herbert Spencer (1820-1903), who devised a theory to explain the problems of social order and change. Spencer compared human societies to living organisms. The parts of an animal, such as the lungs and the heart, are interdependent and contribute to the survival of the total organism. Similarly, Spencer argued, the various parts of society, such as the state and the economy, are also interdependent and work to ensure the stability and survival of the entire system. This theory took care of the problem of order. To explain change, Spencer pushed his analogy even further. Applying Darwin's theory of evolution to human societies, he argued that they gradually evolve from the forms found in the "primitive" societies of the world to the more complex forms found in the industrializing societies of his own time. Spencer believed that evolution means progress, and he strongly opposed attempts at social reform on the grounds that they might interfere with a natural evolutionary process. Spencer's ideas seem rather strange today, but they remain influential in a very modified form. Many sociologists still see society as a more or less harmonious system whose various parts contribute to overall stability. Many also believe there has been a general tendency for societies to move from the simple to the complex, although they do not necessarily equate this evolution with "progress" toward something better.

Karl Marx

The third and most important of the nineteenth-century social thinkers was Karl Marx (1818-1883). Marx was born in Germany, but after being expelled from various countries for his revolutionary activities, he eventually settled in England. He wrote brilliantly on subjects broad and diverse as philosophy, economics, political science,

and history. He did not think of himself as a sociologist, but his work is so rich in sociological insights that he is now regarded as one of the most profound and original sociological thinkers. His influence has been immense. Millions of people accept his theories with almost religious fervor, and modern socialist and communist movements owe their inspiration directly to him.

Emile Durkheim

The French sociologist Emile Durkheim (1858-1917) has strongly influenced the discipline. Durkheim dealt with the problem of social order; he argued that societies are held together by the shared beliefs and values of their members, especially as these are expressed in religious doctrine and ritual. Like Spencer, he wanted to establish how the various parts of society contribute to the maintenance of the whole. His method was to ask what function, or positive consequence for the social system, a given element has—an approach that has been highly influential in modern American sociology. Durkheim also made the first real breakthrough in sociological research with his painstaking statistical study of suicide in various population groups. He was able to show that suicide rates vary consistently from one group to another, proving that the act of suicide is influenced by social forces and is not simply the individual matter that it might appear to be.

Max Weber

The German sociologist Max Weber (1864-1920), a contemporary of Durkheim, has perhaps had a stronger influence on Western sociology than any other single individual. He was a man of prodigious learning whose sociological investigations covered such diverse fields as politics, law, economics, music, cities, and the major world religions. Throughout his adult life Weber felt a great tension between his role as a scholar, dispassionately observing society, and his desire to influence events through political leadership. This tension may have contributed to a severe mental breakdown that incapacitated him for several years of his academic career. He viewed the direction of social change in industrial societies with distaste, feeling that the world was being "disenchanted" by bureaucracy, by the cold rationality of petty experts who knew no value other than efficiency.

Nature or characteristics of Sociology

The following are the main characteristics of sociology as enlisted by Robert Biersted

in his book *"The Social Order"*.

i. Sociology is an Independent Science: Sociology has now emerged into an independent science. It is not treated and studied as a branch of any other science like philosophy or political philosophy or history. As an independent science it has its own field of study, boundary and method.

ii. Sociology is a Social Science and not a Physical Science: Sociology belongs to the family of social sciences and not to the family of physical sciences. As a social science it concentrates its attention on man, his social behavior, social activities and social life. As a member of the family of social sciences it is intimately related to other social sciences like history, political science, economics, psychology, anthropology etc.

iii. Sociology is a Categorical and not a Normative Discipline: Sociology "confines itself to statements about *what is*, not *what should be* or *ought to be*". "As a science, sociology is necessarily silent about questions of value. It does not make any kind of value-judgments. Its approach is neither moral nor immoral but amoral. It is *ethically neutral*."

iv. Sociology is relatively an Abstract Science and not a Concrete Science: This does not mean that sociology is an art and not a science. Nor does it mean, it is unnecessarily complicated and unduly difficult. It only means that sociology is not interested in concrete manifestations of human events. It is more concerned with the *form* of human events and their *patterns*.

v. Sociology is a Generalizing and not a Particularizing or Individualizing Science: Sociology tries to find out the general laws or principles about human interaction and association, about the nature, form, content and structure of human groups and societies. It does not study each and every event that takes place in society. It is not possible also. It tries to make generalizations on the basis of the study of some selected events.

vi. Sociology is a General Science and not a Special Social Science: The area of inquiry of sociology is general and not specialized. It is concerned with human interaction and human life in general. Other social sciences like political science, history, economics etc., also study man and human interaction, but not all

about human interaction. They concentrate their attention on certain aspects of human interaction and activities and specialize themselves in those fields. Sociology studies human activities in a general way.

vii. Finally, Sociology is Both a Rational and an Empirical Science: There are two broad ways of approach to scientific knowledge. One, known as empiricism, is the approach that emphasizes experience and the facts that result from observation and experimentation. The other, known as rationalism, stresses reason and the theories that result from logical inference.

It is clear from the above that sociology is an independent, a social, a categorical, a pure, an abstract, a generalizing, both a rational and an empirical and a general social science.